

Chapter 63-1

This remark made Qiu Zimin immediately perk up.

She stared intently at Liang Father, wishing she could rush forward and snatch his phone to listen to the call herself.

Liang Father, after his initial excitement, regained his composure and simply responded to the person on the other end of the phone.

Two minutes later, Liang Father hung up. Qiu Zimin immediately asked, "How was it? What clue?"

Liang Father frowned deeply, "They found out she was bought by an outsider¹, but after the person bought her, they returned to their hometown. At that time, Hazhou City had too many new constructions, too many migrant workers coming to work, with tens of thousands of people coming and going through the train station daily. It's very difficult to trace specific leads."

After hearing this, Qiu Zimin was greatly disappointed and sighed, "Then isn't that the same as having no clue at all?"

"However.." Qiu Zimin suddenly paused and turned to look at Liang Father, "You said she was bought by an outsider? Then wouldn't that be some poor migrant worker? What would they buy our Nuan Nuan² for? Their family definitely has no money, our Nuan Nuan must have suffered all these years."

Liang Father only sighed silently.

Ever since Qiu Zimin and Liang Shi had their confrontation at home, everyone knew that the family had lost a girl, and that Liang Shi was adopted.

No one mentioned Liang Shi at home anymore.

One day during dinner, Ling Dang said she missed her aunt, and Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed.

This frightened Sun Meirou into constantly giving Ling Dang meaningful looks.

But how could a five-year-old child understand? She said pitifully, "Will I never see Auntie again?"

Before anyone else could speak, Liang Xinhe said, "How could that be impossible? On rest days, I'll take you to visit her."

Qiu Zimin angrily threw down her chopsticks and went upstairs.

Ling Dang blinked and asked, "Is Grandma angry?"

Liang Xinhe comforted her, "It's nothing, you eat your dinner."

After that, everyone in the family avoided this topic.

They all discussed it behind closed doors.

Only Liang Father and Qiu Zimin no longer avoided the family and openly discussed how to find their daughter.

Originally, Qiu Zimin's heart for finding her daughter had died after so many years of searching for a needle in a haystack, but the recently solved Dongling City child abduction case, which reunited so many families, was making headlines online. Every day when she opened her phone, she saw those news stories, making it hard not to be moved.

So her thoughts became active again.

She wondered if her daughter might have been among those in that abduction case.

But her daughter was stolen, while this abduction case mainly involved children aged 4-7.

Those children already had some memories, but her daughter was only a few months old when stolen, with no memories at all.

She might still be in someone else's home calling them mom and dad.

And they were two poor migrant workers at that.

The more Qiu Zimin thought about it, the more heartbroken she became, and she couldn't help but shed a few tears.

Just as Liang Father was about to comfort her, Liang Xinzhou's voice suddenly echoed in the villa, "Dad, are you busy now? I have something to discuss with you."

A very businesslike tone.

Liang Father glanced at Qiu Zimin, patted her shoulder, and said softly, "We've waited so many years, just put your heart at ease. If we can't find her, we can only say it's our fate."

After saying this, he got up and walked toward the study.

Liang Xinzhou was in a suit and tie, his hair combed back meticulously, very much the standard CEO attire.

He followed behind Liang Father, and after closing the study door, he took a seat across from Liang Father.

Footnotes:

¹ Outsider: In this context, refers to someone from outside the local area, typically a migrant worker from rural areas who came to the city for work.

² Nuan Nuan: A pet name meaning "warm/cozy," likely the childhood nickname for their lost daughter.

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Liang Father poured a cup of tea, the fragrant steam slightly diluting the sadness from moments before.

He also poured a cup for Liang Xinzhou. Liang Xinzhou picked it up, took a sip, then asked gently, "Dad, are you still looking for that missing sister?"

Liang Father nodded, "All these years, it's been a constant worry for your mother and me. Finding her would put our hearts at ease, otherwise..."

He paused and smiled bitterly, "I'd feel guilty even on my deathbed."

Back then, it was he who had brought his newborn daughter to the gathering, and it was his carelessness—being busy playing with friends and leaving his daughter aside.

Mr. Gao, who had also lost his daughter along with him, had already passed away.

His family was broken, his wife and children scattered.

That was truly tragic.

But all these years, whenever he thought of Old Gao, his heart felt blocked with grief.

If it weren't for having two other children at home to somewhat alleviate the inner anguish, he probably wouldn't have fared much better either.

Even so, this guilt had weighed on his heart for many years.

After Liang Father finished speaking, he glanced at Liang Xinzhou, "Are you trying to persuade us to stop looking?"

Liang Xinzhou pursed his lips, set his teacup down heavily on the table, removed his glasses to wipe the fog from them, and said bluntly, "Yes, I don't quite understand why you want to find her."

Liang Father frowned, his voice suddenly stern, "What do you mean by that?"

"To be precise, I don't know why you want to find her. If you were determined to find her, then you shouldn't have brought Liang Shi home in the first place." Liang Xinzhou, having worked in the company for years, had developed an increasingly sharp demeanor. Even facing his father, who had dominated the business world for years, he didn't back down. "You brought Liang Shi home, and we all considered her our sister. But now that Liang Shi has grown up, you tell us you've been looking for our real sister all along. Have you considered that this would be hurtful to everyone?"

Liang Father said coldly, "So we should just stop looking? Let your real sister wander outside? Let her suffer hardship?"

"Then have you considered what Liang Shi should do? When your biological daughter comes back, what should Liang Shi do? How can she still set foot in this house? How can she still call you Dad?" Liang Xinzhou said calmly, "If you bring your biological daughter back, the established way our family has interacted all these years will change. We also don't know how to treat a sudden stranger. Blood ties are great, but all these years of getting along together can't be fake either. Initially, it was because of Liang Shi's arrival that Mom stabilized emotionally. She's also an innocent person who got involved. Are we supposed to cut ties with her now?"

Liang Xinzhou analyzed the current situation as coldly as an AI, "Once someone new enters, the ecological balance of our family will be disrupted."

"If your biological daughter is living well outside, harmonious with her adoptive parents, then your appearance would also create waves in her peaceful life, putting her in a difficult position. If she's not living well, then she would have qualities that clash with this social class and this family. The vision, upbringing, demeanor, and etiquette that money can provide—she wouldn't know any of these, having never experienced them. You bring such a person in, desperately trying to make up for lost time, and then what?"

"Everything in this house would have to give way to her, and everyone would have to help her. Your two daughters-in-law both live here—how much energy would they have to spend getting along with this new sister-in-law who has never seen the world?"

"This is still the best-case scenario." After Liang Xinzhou finished speaking, he closed his eyes, "If she has even more flaws, this family could very well fall apart because of her."

Liang Father slammed the table, "What kind of talk is this? She's your real sister. Just because she's been wandering outside for many years, doesn't she deserve to enter the Liang family door?"

"It's not that." Liang Xinzhou remained rational, "If I had to choose between Liang Shi and someone I've never met, I choose Liang Shi."

"She's from a completely different social class than all of you." Liang Father said, "Some child picked up from who knows where. I raised her, gave her food and clothing, let her see so much of the world, but she still became a scoundrel, an uneducated second-generation rich kid, a wastrel. Because of her, I've nearly lost all face!"

"But she's obedient and well-behaved, she's someone we know well, she's a controllable factor." Liang Xinzhou looked at him, "But can you say that because of her waywardness, you gained nothing?"

Liang Xinzhou asked lightly, "If it weren't for her, our cooperation with Huaguang Group wouldn't have been so easy. Without her, our relationship with the Lin family wouldn't be what it is, and we couldn't have become business partners. She may seem unruly, but has she ever done anything to harm the Liang family?"

Liang Father was immediately rendered speechless.

All these years, Liang Xinzhou had always indulged this sister because he knew she wouldn't do anything particularly outrageous.

She might have a chaotic private life, might like gambling and drinking, like calling friends together, playing with disreputable things.

But she had never done a single thing harmful to the Liang family.

She was like walking a tightrope, always on the dangerous edge.

But whenever she reached the edge of harming the Liang family, she would definitely pull back in time.

Liang Xinzhou looked at his father, "I'll leave my words here: if you find your biological daughter and bring her back, given the extent of your and Mom's guilt, this family will definitely be full of constant quarrels."

Liang Father glanced at him, "You're being too hasty with those words."

"Actually, the reasoning is simple." Liang Xinzhou said, "You understand it even without me saying it. If you insist on doing this, Yuwan and I will move out of the old house when the time comes."

Liang Father frowned, "Are you threatening me?"

Liang Xinzhou shook his head, "You know that Yuwan and I plan to have children. We're currently trying to conceive. I don't want her to be distracted by other matters."

Liang Father suddenly slumped in his chair and asked wearily, "Is this because of Liang Shi? Just because she saved you once?"

"Yes, and no." Liang Xinzhou answered after thinking, "I prefer to get along with people I know inside and out. Last time when Liang Shi saved me, it made me realize that getting along is more important than blood ties."

"Actually, like all of you, I once looked forward to our third sister coming back." Liang Xinzhou said, "But later I felt that Liang Shi is my sister, and this family can't handle having another person join. Regardless of whether that person is good or bad."

"So you want us to abandon our biological daughter?" Liang Father asked heavily.

Liang Xinzhou exhaled heavily, "Perhaps you still remember the trolley problem¹ you once told me about?"

A madman tied five people to the tracks, and a trolley was approaching. The trolley could choose to switch tracks, but on the other track, there was also one person.

So should one choose to stay on the original track and kill five people? Or choose to switch tracks and kill one person?

This was a situation where someone was destined to be sacrificed.

Life cannot be weighed on scales, and the value of five people isn't necessarily greater than one person.

But...

For Liang Xinzhou, his choice was absolute.

"The reason is simple." Liang Xinzhou said, "Whether in company management or family building, I choose to protect the option with more people."

So rather than letting an unstable factor enter the family and expose it to too many unknown risks.

Liang Xinzhou chose to sacrifice that biological sister he'd never met.

Liang Father suddenly fell into silence.

Liang Xinzhou stood up, "Of course, you haven't found your daughter yet. I'm just advising you to give up."

"If someday you do find her," Liang Xinzhou said solemnly, "I hope you'll think about what I said today before making your decision."

Footnotes:

¹ Trolley problem: A famous ethical thought experiment in philosophy about moral decision-making when faced with choosing between harmful outcomes.

Chapter 63-3

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The wind was strong at night, and Xu Qingzhu could hear it clearly from the second floor.

It was probably also related to her slight insomnia.

She first lay in bed looking at those comments, as if she were playing with Weibo¹ for the first time. After looking at her own Weibo, she went to look at entries related to Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei. Everyone was cursing in various creative ways, sarcastically making veiled criticisms.

The more she looked, the more excited she became, not feeling tired at all.

Then she went to look at Liang Shi's Weibo.

Her main account name was simply Liang Shi, with the bio stating: An actor who is working hard to improve.

This day happened to coincide with the promotional campaign for "Afterglow," but the trending topics the production team had paid for were all suppressed by Bai Weiwei and the others.

The director must be regretting this to death.

The money spent on trending topics had all gone to waste.

Xu Qingzhu nestled under the covers looking at the "Afterglow" promotional photos.

She had read a bit of the script before Liang Shi's audition, so she had some understanding of this character—a white-turning-black² antagonist. The promotional photos that were released had a great atmospheric quality.

Liang Shi's camera presence was excellent. In this series of officially released posters, only hers and Zhao Ying's posters had that blockbuster quality.

The others, whether due to their appearance or editing issues, were slightly inferior.

Xu Qingzhu directly followed Liang Shi's Weibo with her main account, as well as Zhao Ying, Yang Shuyan, Sally, and Cherry.

Zhou Yi'an hadn't previously reported her Weibo to the company.

She did search online but couldn't find Zhou Yi'an.

However, she did find the Weibo account of RT's Annual Emerging Designer, which had an English name: Leona.

Liang Shi's English name was Leo.

This probably wasn't a coincidence that was actually a coincidence?

But Xu Qingzhu didn't know what Zhou Yi'an was thinking.

Nevertheless, she still followed Zhou Yi'an.

And sent her a private message to thank her.

This person was probably addicted to staying up late, and also liked surfing the internet while staying up late. She replied almost instantly with: ?

But immediately deleted it.

Then said nothing more.

But she followed back.

Xu Qingzhu looked through her following list and found it pitifully small—just two internationally renowned designers, Liang Shi, and herself.

A few seconds later, Sally and Lin Luoxi were added.

After doing all this, Xu Qingzhu planned to sleep, but when she closed her eyes, her mind was full of Liang Shi.

She had methodically arranged for everyone to handle those crises, thoughtfully helped everyone order dinner, and sent everyone off after everything was finished.

Just like their department gathering last time.

Liang Shi did everything perfectly, and could even perceive why she was sensitive and vulnerable during those sensitive and vulnerable moments.

She was such a gentle person.

But so gentle she forgot about herself.

As Xu Qingzhu thought about this, she started thinking about her series of crisis management operations during the day.

Since she couldn't sleep anyway, she got up and made a spreadsheet, listing out Liang Shi's entire process from today.

She had thought of everything.

Even implicating Dongheng's rival Changli.

She had cast an enormous net.

Although she didn't know what Liang Shi had called Zhou Yi'an to discuss, she must have obtained some even more significant evidence.

Xu Qingzhu guessed it was related to the previous Huayue International incident.

But the fact that Liang Shi held onto that information also showed she held onto her moral boundaries.

There was no need to use such dirty personal matters to attack people.

Liang Shi had arranged everything with great discretion.

At this moment, Xu Qingzhu didn't even think about who she really was, but kept thinking: could such a perfect person exist in this world?

Didn't she have any weaknesses?

Was she this good to everyone? This considerate?

Or was it only toward her?

Xu Qingzhu couldn't even tell if she was curious or... if she liked her.

It seemed like she did, a little.

Such a person—it seemed no one wouldn't like them.

Just like Zhao Xuning, who used to really dislike her, didn't she also find the current Liang Shi very charismatic?

This kind of personal charm made her entire being shine.

So in the quiet late hours, Xu Qingzhu opened her tablet's drawing software and drew Liang Shi.

By the time she realized it, Liang Shi's image was already vivid on the paper.

Afterward, she dispersed those romantic thoughts and forced herself to sleep.

When she found herself unable to think about Liang Shi rationally, she went to another extreme—if something is too perfect, it must be a disguise.

Time passed as she overthought things.

Around the time when dawn was breaking, she finally fell asleep.

When the alarm went off, it startled her awake.

But she still had to force herself to get up for work.

She couldn't slack off today either.

And on her bedside tablet, when opened, there was the portrait she had drawn last night.

She sat on the edge of the bed and drank some water before finally calming her emotions.

Being curious about and appreciating someone didn't mean anything.

She comforted herself this way.

Then went to wash up, discovering in the mirror that she had two big dark circles. She used a lot of concealer before barely managing to cover them.

As a result, when she came downstairs and saw Liang Shi, Liang Shi's first words were: "Teacher Xu, your all-nighter skills are really improving!"

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She sat at the dining table, looking at the bread on her plate without much energy, "Is it that obvious?"

Liang Shi nodded, placing milk in front of Xu Qingzhu while she had soy milk in front of herself, "You followed my Weibo at 3:30 AM last night."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She coughed to cover her embarrassment, "Accident."

Liang Shi just smiled helplessly, "Go to bed earlier from now on."

Xu Qingzhu mumbled a response, then left.

Footnotes:

¹ Weibo: China's equivalent of Twitter, a popular social media platform for microblogging.

² White-turning-black: A Chinese term (白切黑) referring to a character who appears innocent and pure on the surface but is actually manipulative or villainous underneath; can also refer to a character who transforms from good to evil.

Chapter 63-4

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Life went on as usual.

The events of that day were like a gust of wind—after blowing past, they scattered.

They continued to hold fast to their positions.

By Friday, Zhou Li had to go out on fieldwork at the last minute and could only ask Liang Shi again to help her pick up Rainbow.

Liang Shi happily accepted this task, thinking she could take the opportunity to see Qi Jiao.

She arrived at the kindergarten entrance early and first saw Ling Dang. The two of them spent some time being affectionate.

Ling Dang nestled in her arms, continuously seeking hugs pitifully.

Liang Shi simply carried her directly to pick up Rainbow.

After picking her up, she put both of them in the car, then waited for Qi Jiao to appear.

She waited until all the kindergarten children had left and the vehicles parked at the entrance had all dispersed.

Only then did Qi Jiao appear at the entrance.

She was carrying a beige bag, wearing a blue long dress with a white jacket over it.

Not much different from her usual style.

Liang Shi approached to greet her, clearly startling her. She asked warily, "What are you doing?"

"Just saying hello." Liang Shi said, "It's been too long since we've seen each other."

"There's no need." Qi Jiao said as she was about to leave, "We're not familiar with each other."

Liang Shi was about to approach and ask her something when she saw the wounds on the back of Qi Jiao's neck.

Dense scabs of dried blood.